

Specimens, brought up from the deep, are dried to preserve them

Brittle star's arms wound around sea pen for support

Dried specimens of deep-sea brittle stars (*Asteronyx loveni*)

Long arms can grasp food drifting by in the water

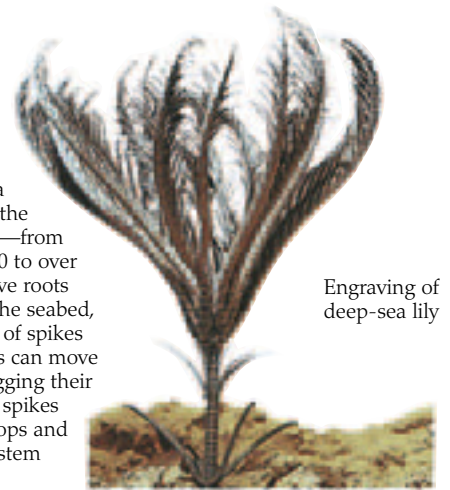
Stem of sea pen grows up from the seabed

ALL IN THE ARMS

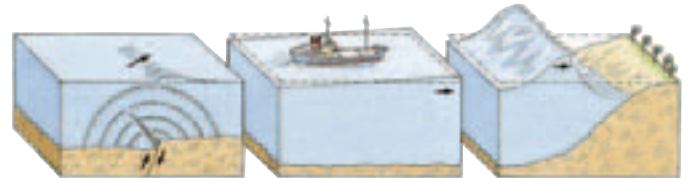
These deep-sea brittle stars are usually found wound around sea pens on the ocean floor. They use their long, snakelike arms to cling onto the sea pen and to feed on small creatures and other food particles drifting by. Climbing off the seabed gives the brittle stars a better chance to collect food. Brittle stars and sea pens are common bottom-dwellers from shallow water to the deep sea in oceans around the world. These deep-sea brittle stars live at depths of 300–6,000 ft (100–1,800 m).

LILY OF THE DEEP

Sea lilies use their feathery arms to gather food particles from the water. Many kinds of sea lilies live on the floor of the deep sea in the trenches—from 300 to over 26,500 ft (100 to over 8,000 m) deep. Some have roots and stems anchored to the seabed, while those with whorls of spikes (cirri) around their stems can move by using their arms, dragging their stems behind them. The spikes along the stem act as props and those at the base of the stem can grip the seabed.



Engraving of deep-sea lily



STARTING ON THE BOTTOM

Tsunamis are often called tidal waves, but they are not caused by tides. They begin because of earthquakes or eruptions on the seabed, sending out shock waves through the water. Traveling across the open sea at great speed, the waves are usually around 2 ft (0.5 m) high. When they near the coast, they bunch up to make towering walls of water that can devastate anything on land.

FLOWER BASKETS

The glassy skeletons of Venus flower basket sponges have long been admired for their beauty. The Japanese viewed them as symbols of wedded bliss, because pairs of shrimps were often found inside them. The living sponge is not as attractive because it is covered with soft tissues. Most glass sponges live in deep waters, but some live in shallower waters in cold, polar regions.

Opening of sponge covered with sieve plate

Glassy skeleton

Victorian display of a dried Venus flower basket (*Euplectella aspergillum*)